

more than sufficient for near-CD-quality MP3s ripped from audio CDs. In fact, it's more than likely that you would choose a lower bitrate in order to fit more songs into the available space.

Some players offer support for the Ogg Vorbis (.ogg) and ASF formats as well. Ogg Vorbis is an open source audio encoding technique that offers the same quality as MP3 compression, at lower file sizes.

Playing WMAs eats through the battery life faster than when you play MP3s, because of the more complex computations needed to decode WMA. The difference can be as much as 25 per cent!

Sony's NW series need bundled software called SonicStage to synchronise the player with a PC. The software converts the music files on the computer to a proprietary format before transferring them to the player. The conversion and transfer is a slow process, and takes up CPU resources as well.

FM reception and recording is now more of a norm than an exception. But when we tested them, not all the players were able to pick up weak radio signals. If you're taking a morning walk, FM reception on your player shouldn't be a problem, but some of these players might act up if you try to tune in to your favourite station indoors or in a bus.

Most—but not all—players allow you to record FM broadcasts. Some

video are provided in some mid-range players (videos have to be converted to certain formats before they can be played). The tiny screens do little justice to movies, though.

The YES YMP models—the 920, 921, 922 and 928—can play video, while the SAFA 800 series offer JPEG viewing. The YES 922 takes the feature list beyond music and video capabilities with a TV remote control feature. Now, just what else can you pack into an MP3 player?

Evaluating Sound Quality

If 10 people are each given 10 music players to choose the best from, you'll possibly have five different best players. What sounds good to someone may sound average to others. You might prefer to turn off the equaliser, and your friend finds bliss only when the bass is blasting away. In our tests, though, we kept the equalisers off, so as to reduce this subjective element.

Cutting across brands, we found one common characteristic amongst entry-level and mid-range players—nearly all of them reproduced bass with acceptable quality. The same does not go for the treble, however. This means that while your 160 beats-per-minute trance tracks will sound fine, classical music will not seem quite as rich as you'd like. This is probably a balancing act by the manufacturers—most music today



might produce a noticeable hiss during recording, but the recorded files will be free of noise.

Recording is mostly done in the .WAV format, which is less demanding on the encoding logic circuitry and easy on power consumption. But WAV occupies more space. Mid-range and high-end players usually offer MP3 recording at a bitrate of 64 to 360 kbps. Some players also feature direct line-in recording, turning the MP3 player into an all-in-one mobile recording device.

Some players go beyond sound and offer video on the move. Native support for JPEG and

is bass-heavy, at least the kind of songs that the 18-25-year-old target consumer presumably listens to. If fast-paced, bass-heavy music is what you like, the MuVo series from Creative or the XFL series from XFREE fits your bill, with not too much of a trade-off on treble. At high volumes, though—which, by the way, we don't recommend, for the sake of your ears—some jarring does occur.

An exception to this was the Samsung YP C1, which, while doing a neat job with the treble, simply ate away the bass, taking away the kick